

Eunectes murinus

Green anaconda



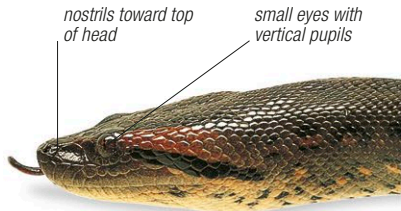
Length 20–33 ft (6–10 m)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America, Trinidad



With a maximum weight approaching 550 lb (250 kg), the green anaconda is the world's heaviest snake. It spends most of its life partially submerged in

shallow water, and favors areas with thick waterside vegetation, where it can move around unseen. Green anacondas hunt mainly after dark. They lie in wait for mammals such as capybaras and deer, and can even kill fully grown caimans; there are also records of them attacking people, sometimes with fatal results. Males are smaller than females, but have large pelvic spurs, which they use during courtship. Females produce litters of 4–80 young, which take about 6 years to reach maturity. Anacondas may have a lifespan of 25 years or more.



nostrils toward top of head
small eyes with vertical pupils



relatively small head

smooth scales

small, light-centered markings on flanks

oval black markings on olive-green back

GIANT CONSTRUCTOR
The green anaconda's powerful body is strong enough to asphyxiate animals up to the size of a horse. It often ambushes its victims as they arrive to drink.

ADAPTED TO WATER



The green anaconda's eyes and nostrils are positioned toward the top of its head, enabling the snake to see and breathe while partially submerged in water.

Aspidites melanocephalus

Black-headed python



Length 5–8½ ft (1.5–2.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. Australia



The black-headed python is slender-bodied and has a jet-black head and neck, with irregular brown and cream bars across its body. Not an aggressive snake, it retreats into a burrow or crevice if a predator threatens—usually a mammal or bird of prey. Its diet consists of small mammals, birds, and reptiles, including venomous snakes. Females lay up to 18 eggs at a time, under logs or roots, and in chambers underground. Like most pythons, they coil around the eggs to protect them and regulate their temperature until they hatch.



Antaresia childreni

Children's python



Length 30 in (75 cm), max 39 in (100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. Australia



Named after the Victorian zoologist J.G. Children, this small Australian python spends much of its time hidden away in caves and rock crevices. It specializes in eating lizards, but also ambushes birds and small mammals, including bats. If attacked, it defends itself by striking and biting but, like all pythons, it is nonvenomous. Male Children's pythons have longer and thicker tails than the females. Juveniles have darker markings than adults.

PARENTAL CARE



Seen here coiled protectively around her eggs to regulate their temperature until they hatch, the female Children's python lays a clutch of 8–10 eggs each year, or every other year, in a hollow tree or an underground chamber.

SMALL SNAKE
Very small for a python, this snake is brown or reddish brown, with darker but often faint blotches.



faint dark blotches

Morelia spilota

Carpet python



Length 6½ ft (2 m), max 13 ft (4 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. New Guinea, Australia



The carpet python is one of Australia's most widespread snakes, found in an unusually wide range of habitats. It is also one of the most variable, with several subspecies, each with a different common name. One feature shared by all subspecies is a bold pattern of irregular markings—which can be brown, gray, reddish brown, or black—laid over variously colored backgrounds. Carpet pythons are active both by night and by day, hunting lizards, birds, and small mammals. Like other pythons, they are nonvenomous, but they can inflict a painful bite. Female carpet pythons lay clutches of about 50 soft-shelled eggs in decaying vegetation or hollow tree trunks, coiling protectively around them until they hatch.

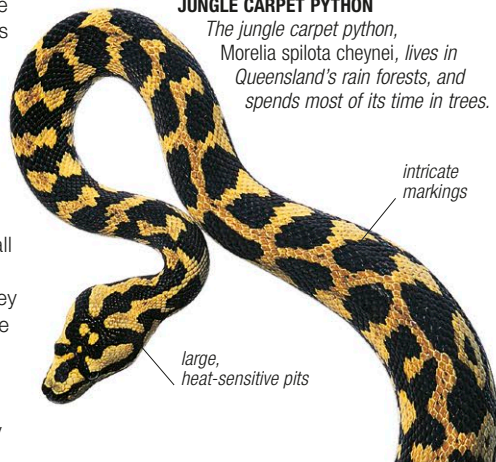
DIAMOND PYTHON



The diamond python, *Morelia spilota spilota*, is the most distinctive subspecies, with an intricate pattern of diamond-shaped blotches from head to tail.

JUNGLE CARPET PYTHON

The jungle carpet python, *Morelia spilota cheynei*, lives in Queensland's rain forests, and spends most of its time in trees.



intricate markings

large, heat-sensitive pits